

**Rockingham County Schools
Board of Education
Central Administrative Offices
511 Harrington Highway
Eden, NC 27288**

**February 24, 2025
Work Session
1:00 p.m.**

Open Session Minutes

Present: Ms. Paula Rakestraw, Board Chair and Ms. Kimberly McMichael, Vice Chair. Board Members: Ms. Vicky Alston, Mr. Philip Butler, Ms. Vickie McKinney, Mr. Daniel Rakes and Mr. Bob Wyatt. Administrative staff: Dr. Shawn Stover, Superintendent; Dr. Charles Perkins, Assistant Superintendent of Curriculum and Instruction; Dr. Cindy Corcoran, Assistant Superintendent of Support Services; Ms. Erselle Young, Assistant Superintendent of Operations and Logistics; Ms. Annie Ellis, Chief Financial Officer; Mr. Lowell Rogers, Executive Director of Human Resources; Mr. Brandon McPherson, Board Attorney and Ms. Renee Brown, Board Assistant were present.

CALL TO ORDER

Ms. Rakestraw called the meeting to order.

ROLL CALL

The Board members stated their names. Six members were present at roll call.

ANNOUNCEMENTS

The next Board Meeting is scheduled for Monday, March 17, 2025. The meeting begins at 4:00 p.m. at Central Administrative Offices located at 511 Harrington Highway, Eden, NC.

There is a Work Session scheduled for Monday, March 31, 2025. The meeting begins at 1:00 p.m. at Central Administrative Offices, located at 511 Harrington Highway, Eden, NC.

Ms. Rakestraw stated that the district is receiving numerous requests and proposals related to redistricting, a potential new school, and facility additions. She emphasized that the Facilities Committee and staff are actively reviewing these matters and will present their recommendations to the Board in the form of a decision point memo at the June meeting.

APPROVAL OF AGENDA

Ms. McMichael moved to approve the agenda, seconded by Ms. Alston. The vote was 6/0 Unanimously Approved.

CONSENT AGENDA

Ms. Rakestraw explained that the items on the Consent Agenda are considered non-controversial. However, she encouraged anyone with questions to reach out to staff for further clarification.

Presented consent items for Board consideration:

1. Approval Consent - Summer Program - Dr. Charles Perkins and Mr. Jason Hyler
2. Approval Consent - Naming the DMHS Track Facility After Former Coach Steve Yannotti - Dr. Perkins
3. Approval Consent - Energy Grant - Ms. Erselle Young
4. Approval Consent - Request to Adjust April 28, 2025 Board Meeting Time - Dr. Stover
(Attachment 1-A)
5. Approval Consent - Student Assignment Timeline - Dr. Cindy Corcoran (Attachment 2-A)

Action: Ms. McMichael moved that the Board approve the consent item as presented.
Ms. McKinney seconded the motion. The vote was 6/0. Unanimously
Approved.

Daniel Rakes joined the meeting at 1:02 PM.

ACTION ITEMS

Approval - 2nd Reading of the RCS Traditional, Early College and Dillard Calendars

Ms. Rakestraw recognized Dr. Perkins for the 2nd reading of calendars. Dr. Perkins presented the second reading of the 2025-26 Rockingham County Schools (RCS) calendars, including Traditional, Dillard, and Early College schedules. The draft calendars were open for public review and feedback, with 298 responses received. (Attachment 3-A)

Key points:

- RCS follows an instructional hours model, requiring 1,025 hours per year.
- The Traditional Calendar includes 175 student days and 215 staff days.
- Public preference (70%) favored Option 1 for Spring Break (April 6–10, 2026).
- Early College staff requested calendar adjustments:
 - October 15 as a Required Teacher Workday.
 - March 9 as an Optional Teacher Workday.

Action: Mr. Butler moved to approve Option 1 for the RCS Traditional, Early College staff request adjustments, and the Dillard calendar as presented. Mr. Wyatt seconded the motion. The vote was 7/0. Unanimously Approved.

Dr. Perkins requested **approval to adjust the 2024-2025 RCS Traditional Calendar** to accommodate the closure on Thursday, February 20, 2025. The proposed adjustments are as follows:

- Wednesday, March 26, 2025 – Change from an early release day to a full student day.
- Thursday, March 27, 2025 – Change from a required teacher workday to an early release day.
- Friday, March 28, 2025 – Required teacher workday.

Board members asked questions and commented on the information presented.

Action: Mr. Butler moved that the Board approve the recommendation as presented.
Mr. Rakes seconded the motion. The vote was 7/0. Unanimously
Approved.

Dr. Perkins announced the dates for the 2025 high school graduation ceremonies as follows:

- **Morehead High School** – Wednesday, June 4, 2025
- **Reidsville High School** – Wednesday, June 4, 2025
- **Rockingham County High School** – Thursday, June 5, 2025
- **Dalton McMichael High School** – Thursday, June 5, 2025

REPORTS/DISCUSSION ITEMS

2025-2026 Proposed Budget

Ms. Rakestraw recognized Ms. Ellis for the Proposed 2025-2026 Budget. Dr. Ellis presented the PowerPoint presentation for the proposed 2025-2026 budget for Rockingham County Schools. The total budget is projected at **\$173,732,637.39**, reflecting an increase of **\$2,394,130.13** from the previous year. Additional discussions focused on personnel costs, including projected salary increases for central office administrators, teachers, and support staff. Further deliberation will take place before final approval. Board members asked questions and commented on the information presented.

(Attachment 4-A)

RCS Instructional Support Services Department Report - Part 2

Dr. Corcoran and the Instructional Support Services Department provided an update on district initiatives aimed at enhancing student outcomes. Key highlights include:

- **Collaboration & Teams:** The department works closely with Curriculum & Instruction and manages various district teams, including MTSS, Behavior & Mental Health, Risk Assessment, and Strategic Plan Revision teams.
- **Strategic Plan Goal:** Focus on implementing a comprehensive behavioral health model aligned with the Multi-Tiered Systems of Support (MTSS) framework.
- **Strengths Identified:** Strong leadership, established teaming structures, a clear MTSS framework, and robust instructional intervention models.
- **Growth Areas:** Enhancing stakeholder communication, improving data-driven problem-solving, and increasing support for data interpretation and action steps.
- **Social-Emotional Behavior Teams:** A multidisciplinary team meets monthly to identify at-risk students, monitor progress, and implement interventions.
- **Mental Health Services:** The "Stepping Stones" program provides clinical assessments, psychotherapy (individual and group), family therapy, and crisis management within a 32-hour direct care model.
- **Exceptional Children's (EC) Program:**
 - Staff of 345 serves 2,159 students.
 - Services include inclusion, homebound, compliance monitoring, student transitions, and specialized instruction.
 - Personnel include teachers, therapists, psychologists, interpreters, and specialists.

The department continues to focus on student well-being, instructional support, and compliance while identifying areas for growth in communication and data utilization. Board members asked questions and commented on the information presented.

School Presentations

Dillard Academy Presentation

Dr. Norton, along with staff and two students, presented a presentation on Dillard Academy's Year-Round Learning Model and its commitment to personalized education, STEAM integration, and community engagement.

Key Highlights:

- **Year-Round Learning Benefits:** Reduces summer learning loss, enhances student engagement, improves attendance, and provides consistent childcare options.
- **Academic Focus:** Emphasizes STEAM (Science, Technology, Engineering, Arts, and Mathematics) with hands-on, inquiry-based learning.
- **Student Support & Engagement:** Includes before/after-school care, PBIS incentives, and extracurricular programs such as the Lego Club, Battle of the Books, and the Boys 2 Men initiative.
- **Community & Character Development:** Encourages service projects, leadership, and positive behavior recognition through Dalmatian Spirit and Pride initiatives.

SPLASH Program Presentation

Mr. Eanes and Ms. Herrera from Bethany Elementary School, along with Ms. Pruitt and staff members from Stoneville Elementary School, provided an insightful overview of the SPLASH Program, an immersive dual-language initiative. This program immerses English-speaking students in a Spanish-only environment, with English Language Arts instruction integrated starting in second grade. By the end of the program, students achieve bilingualism, biliteracy, and bicultural competence, with Spanish proficiency nearing that of native speakers.

Key Highlights:

- **Academic Performance:** SPLASH students demonstrated higher achievement in math, reading, and science compared to their grade-level peers.
- **Cognitive & Social Benefits:** Participation enhances critical thinking, communication, adaptability, and self-esteem, preparing students for a global society.
- **Strategic Alignment:** The program supports the district's Pillar of Excellence I: Instructional, emphasizing resource maximization to promote student success.
- **Promotional Efforts:** SPLASH is being marketed via billboards, flyers, brochures, and the district website to increase awareness and enrollment.
- **Enrollment Updates:** Applications for the 2025-2026 school year open March 10 at 6 PM.

Next Steps: Continued support for expansion, increased promotional efforts, and assessment of long-term program impact.

Board members asked questions and commented on the information presented.

Parent Organizations Report

Dr. Stover presented the Parent Organization Report. Each school principal reviewed and signed the report to ensure its accuracy. **(Attachment 5-A)**

School Marketing Report

Marketing Initiatives Discussion:

Dr. Stover presented initial marketing ideas for the school system, as requested during the January 27th Work Session. He outlined strategies to enhance district-wide programming visibility and attract families to Rockingham County Schools. The key initiatives included:

- **Marketing Videos:** The district has created or is in the process of creating promotional videos highlighting specialty program schools. A completed video for the CTE Innovative High School was shared as an example.
- **Board Work Session Highlights:** Schools will be strategically featured at Board Work Sessions, incorporating various stakeholders to showcase their unique programs.

- **School-Specific Brochures:** The graphic designer responsible for the district's strategic plan has been engaged to develop high-quality brochures. These will be tailored to each school, emphasizing their strengths and offerings.
- **Exploring a Marketing Professional:** The district is actively seeking funding opportunities to hire a marketing professional to refine and enhance the overall marketing strategy.

Dr. Stover requested feedback from the Board regarding these initiatives and invited suggestions for additional marketing strategies.

Committee Reports

Each committee listed below presented the following information: Committee Members, Goal of the Committee and Summary of Actions

- Board Policy Committee - Presented by Ms. McMichael

The Board took a ten-minute break at 2:40 p.m.

CLOSED SESSION

Action: Mr. Butler moved for the Rockingham County Board of Education to enter Closed Session, to discuss confidential personnel information, pursuant to N.C. General Statute §143-318.11(a)(1), and (a)(6), and to consult with the Board's attorney in order to preserve the attorney-client privilege, pursuant to N.C. General Statute §143.318.11(a)(3). Mr. Rakes seconded the motion. The motion carried on a vote of 7/0. The Board moved into closed session at 2:48 pm.

Action: Mr. Alston moved to return to open session, seconded by Mr. Rakes. The motion carried unanimously.

Mr. Lowell Rogers presented the Personnel Report during the closed session. Please refer to (Attachment 6 -A) for further details.

Action: Ms. McKinney moved to accept the personnel report as presented. Seconded by Mr. Rakes, motion carried on a vote of 7/0.

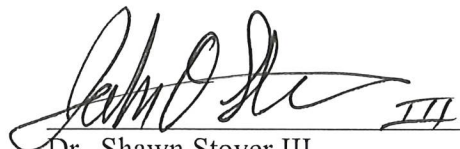
Action: Ms. McMichael moved to adjourn, seconded by Ms. Alston. The vote passed 7/0.

Adjourned at 3:15 p.m.

Minutes read and approved:



Ms. Paula Rakestraw, Board Chair
Rockingham County Board of Education



Dr. Shawn Stover III
Superintendent of Schools

March 17, 2025

